

Fix the world

Those of you who have read this magazine over the years probably found something strange with page 1 this month. Traditionally, the first page of this magazine has been reserved for the editor's column, and sometimes carries a message from the publisher. We've never given anyone outside of this company that first page. It's not a rule that's written anywhere, or something that the company has taken a conscious decision about; it's just always seemed morally correct. I know a lot of other magazines do it, and get premium rates for the page too, but we don't.

Perhaps like every editor before me, I also promised myself to not let page 1 be used as a gimmick – to try something new, to make a statement, or to get premium ad rates. I also promised myself that the page would always deal with technology. I'm going back on those promises, and I'm not sorry.

I'm a huge legal torrent buff, and a month ago, I came across the movie, *The Yes Men fix the World*. Thanks to an unlimited internet connection, I had no qualms when clicking Download.

I'll be honest, I've never liked the gimmicks and stunts people pull to get attention (and, yes, I abhor reality TV). Had someone told me this movie was about a couple of scamsters who pulled elaborate stunts to embarrass big corporations, I probably would have ignored it. I'm thankful no one did, because I thoroughly enjoyed every minute, and learnt that gimmicks and stunts are sometimes very necessary – for the right reasons.

My very first thought was to share this movie with you, but that just wasn't enough. Those of you who bought this magazine from the news stand probably saw the movie advertised on the packaging. And for those of you who didn't, or those who subscribe, my little "stunt" was to bring it to your notice.

I don't want you to watch the movie just because it shows two guys getting a little payback for the Bhopal gas tragedy that our country faced – if you consider causing stock prices of The Dow Chemical Company (who bought Union Carbide) to fall a couple of billion dollars "little payback", that is. Nor do I want you to watch the movie because it's very funny and entertaining... which it is. The most important message I found in this movie was that ordinary people like you and I can actually "do something" about the injustices

in the world. For all those of you who think, "I'm just one person, what can I accomplish?", this movie is your answer.

The Yes Men try and make money by selling DVDs of their movies, and ask for donations on their web site – it's obvious they need money for their projects to continue. Yet, when I told them I wanted to share their movie with you, but had no budgets to buy their movie, all they asked for in return was to carry a note on behalf of the victims of Bhopal. Genuine nice guys!

I urge you to follow their exploits, and support them in any way that you can. I'll be donating \$19.84 to their Yes Labs project at <http://theyesmen.org>, because that's a donation amount they came up with to commemorate the Bhopal tragedy. I hope the more well-to-do amongst you will watch the movie and consider doing the same, to empower The Yes Men to continue playing havoc with corporations that thoroughly deserve it; and even if you can't donate, you can follow their example and start caring a little more.

You can choose to care by indulging in activism, like the Yes Men, or just choose to care enough to find out more about the brands you buy products from. Just as the Yes Men use technology to aid them with their endeavours, you too can make technology work for you.

Use our Consumer Protection initiative when a company tries to stiff you out of your rights, and recommend that as a solution to friends who face problems with service. Use our Forum (thinkdigit.com/forum) to let other consumers like yourself know about your experiences with a company – good or bad. Do a little research online about a company before you buy products; look for how much investment it makes in green initiatives, etc. Recycle your old hardware, and as far as possible try and donate it to people or institutions that need it more than you do... Just choose not to be a silent spectator, and you will be doing enough.

Also, remember to send feedback about the movie, to us and to the Yes Men, and also send in your suggestions about how we can collectively work to keep big corporations from being complacent about their moral obligations. 



"...all they asked for in return was to carry a note on behalf of the victims of Bhopal. Genuine nice guys!"

Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

